



BEFORE

Earlier great powers of the Middle East set the scene for Persian conquest of the region.

ASSYRIAN EMPIRE

The Assyrian kings **80–81** had ruled lands between the Zagros Mountains of Iran and the Mediterranean. They led campaigns into **Egypt** and into the mountains of **Armenia**. When their **empire fell** in 612 BCE, they left rich cities and trade links open for exploitation by their successors.

NEW BABYLON

The bulk of Assyrian lands were taken over by a dynasty ruling from the ancient city of **Babylon 55, 79, 90**.

These Neo-Babylonian kings rebuilt Babylon into an imperial capital. Although it fell to the Persian army less

than a century later, Babylonian techniques of rulership were influential in the next 200 years, inspiring a text of Cyrus (see right) and the redevelopment of cities, such as Susa (see right).



DETAIL OF ISHTAR GATE, BABYLON, c. 580 BCE

On the territorial margins of the great powers of Mesopotamia—Assyria and Babylonia (see pp.80–81 and BEFORE)—resided several small states and peoples. Among these were the Medes and Persians. Greek historians, influenced by Persian views, describe how the Medes first developed a luxurious empire to match their Mesopotamian neighbors. Of the Persians who attended their court, one individual, Cyrus, supposedly took over the Medes’ empire from within. Archaeological remains do not back up this account, however. Contemporary chronicles unearthed in Babylon instead tell how Cyrus conquered lands surrounding Mesopotamia in the mid-

6th century BCE before moving on the capitals of the heartland itself. First to fall was the Lydian kingdom in the west of modern Turkey. This conquest brought Cyrus within sight of Greece. Next to fall to Cyrus was the Babylonian king Nabonidus and his capital. Detailed Babylonian and Mediterranean records also recall the victories of Cyrus’s son Cambyses, who invaded Egypt in 524 BCE. Cyrus’s conquests of extensive areas

in central Asia in the east are less well documented. With Cambyses’ annexation of Egypt, the Persians—a small tribal elite from the Iranian plateau—had acquired a world empire within a generation, creating huge pressures on the leaders. When

Cambyses died, his brother Bardiya seems to have been recognized as king. But the loudest voice in the following years is that of Darius I, who alleged in a

“A Persian man has delivered battle far indeed from Persia”

TOMB INSCRIPTION OF DARIUS I, 549–486 BCE

The Persian Empire

From provincial beginnings, a dynasty of kings—the Achaemenids—emerged to exert power across the continent of Asia from the Mediterranean to northwest India. The empire of the Persian kings was one of an unprecedented scale.

Persepolis

A griffin head designed to sit at the top of a column watches over Persepolis, the city developed by Darius I and his successors from 519 BCE. The structures included massive columned audience halls (right) and (in the distance) smaller royal palaces built of stone and mud-brick.

